

Interviewer: First of all, how would you like us to name your partner?

Participant: [Name].

I: How long have you been with [Partner's Name]?

P: Almost [6-10] years.

I: I'd like you to tell me about your relationship, your love story.

P: We've been married for [1-5], [1-5]1/2 years. We met in [City], we were both living there. Then we moved in together, I think, [1-5] year or [1-5] after we met. And recently, we moved to [Country] together. We're in [City]. We're accomplices. We're... How can I put it? We don't fight, you know. I mean, if... If we're angry with each other, it rarely lasts long. We manage to get out of each other's way quickly. And we respect and support each other. I know I can count on her in difficult times and vice versa. That's all I can say for now.

I: You say you met in [City]. How did that happen? How did you get together?

P: She had organized a party at her place and I had been invited by some of her roommates' friends. And I remember, as soon as I walked into the room she was in, I met her eyes and she kind of held them, and I kind of held her eyes. And I remember thinking "Wow, she's beautiful! I'd love to talk to her during the evening." And I tried to amuse her during the evening. So she had these roller skates in her room that I think she'd never tried before. And so I asked her if I could borrow them. It was during the party. And so I made roller skates in the living room to amuse her. And also to amuse him, to entertain people, I suggested that we make a human pyramid that evening. So that's how I met her. It was at a party at her place, and I tried to get her attention.

I: And after that, how did it go from being a couple, let's say, to being married? So we were together for [1-5] years, or [1-5] years, when I proposed. And it was mainly because she talked to me about marriage. For example, when we'd go hiking and talk, she'd have fun imagining the guest list for her wedding. So I figured it was something that was important to her, whereas I'd never imagined myself getting married. But at the same time, I liked the idea of having a party, of celebrating our love. So I proposed and she said yes. And in the weeks that followed, we talked about why we were doing it. And so I told her it was because I thought it was important for her. And then she kind of told me that not so much, but so much the better if we get married, it's going to be a beautiful moment. But then I thought it was funny that, for once, we hadn't had good communication. Because, yeah, she was just talking about it, about getting married. But in the end, it turned out fine. And it was too good. It was such a beautiful weekend in the [Country]. We had all our families, all our friends, and we received an enormous amount of affection and love from our friends and families. And I think it was the weekend that made us want to come back and live in [Country]. So it was all very positive. And I don't think it changed a lot of things for us. We still call each other... I say my girlfriend, she says my boyfriend. And I don't feel much more committed or that we could ever separate since we got married. It hasn't changed much. Yeah, in that respect.

I: And the move to [Country] went well too?

P: Yeah, it went well. I remember [Name] saying how nice it was that we were going to start an adventure together again. And I noticed once again that I could count on her, that she supported

me when I was a bit more in a downward spiral back here. And she supported me when it was her. So those were the first [1-5] months, which were difficult for both of us, because we had to meet new people, and even if we still do, it's still a bit difficult. But as a couple, I thought it was really positive that we were doing this together. And I was really happy about that, getting closer to her. And then we went back to [City] because [Name] got her citizenship. We knew it had to be in person, her [Nationality] citizenship. And so, when we were in the midst of settling in here, it kind of cut me off or set me back a bit to go back to [City] and meet up with all our friends. So the second trip back was harder. And right now, I don't feel like I've gotten that close to her. The week, since we came back the second time, than when we first came back.

I: Okay. If you had to compare the quality of your relationship with the quality of your friends' relationships, what would you say?

P: The quality of my friends' relationships or that my friends have as a couple?

I: Yes, that your friends have as a couple.

P: So, we can't qualify the quality, can we?

I: Yes, not compare the quality.

P: Yeah, compare. I have the impression that we communicate better than maybe the average of my friends in couples. We communicate better in the sense that we manage to understand each other. If we disagree, we try to listen to each other and understand why we disagree, what happened. I also have the impression, compared perhaps with other friends, that the quality of our friendly relations is a little more important. I also have the impression, perhaps compared to other friends, that we're more similar in terms of stereotypes. That we don't have all the gender stereotypes that some of my friends have. I feel like there are pairs of friends where there's the guy and the girl, and they each have their own very defined, very clear role. I feel that with [Name], the gender gap is a little closer. We understand each other more than some of my friends. I'm fully aware that there are typically male roles, in DIY for example. And that there are typically more feminine roles, like coming up with an idea for a meal, which I'll sometimes rely on [Name] for. So in terms of tasks, maybe I'm stretching myself too far, but in terms of comparisons with my friends, I get the impression that [Name] and I are more alike in terms of gender. I'm not sure how to explain that.

I: No problem. And does that seem to contribute to the quality of your relationship?

P: It's a very important thing for me. Afterwards, maybe more in general, but I want to be able to have as many girl friends as boy friends. So I don't want the other person in my relationship to seem different from me. I want us to understand each other. And so, it's important for me that the other person can also, from time to time, identify with the other gender on certain points. There has to be that understanding.

I: And if you had to compare it to your previous relationships, what would you say?

P: I only had one relationship before [Name], a long one. And what didn't work was communication. There was the fact that she's American, my ex-girlfriend, so she spoke English. She spoke a little French, but not very well. I spoke English well, but I didn't express myself the way I would in French.

So the subtleties weren't there. A lot of things got lost in communication. And I had a lot of trouble with the fact that she could hold a grudge. In fact, I think I had a hard time when people were angry with me. So, it puts you in unpleasant inner states. Just like my ex could give me the cold shoulder for several hours, or even a day or two. That didn't work for me. Whereas [Name], as I said, it's more like a ten-minute discussion. And then it was up to us. And the other thing that wasn't working and is working now is that my ex, whose name is [NAME], was very directive. So, on trips or even in everyday life, she wanted to decide on the eight-year job, the program. And she didn't leave me much room to express what I wanted. And that was a problem for me. I always felt like I couldn't assert myself. But with [Name], it's clearly easier. There are times when she expresses her desire clearly, and that's the way it's going to be. Because for one thing or another, it's important to her that it's a certain way. So I accept that. But I also know that when there are things I want, that I want to propose, I really have the space to do it.

I: So it was communication and diversity, actually, that worked the same way.

P: Yeah.

I: I'd like you to tell me what a high-quality relationship is for you.

P: For me, a high-quality relationship means trust, a lot of trust. In the sense that if one of the people in the couple needs more space at certain times, needs to invest in personal projects, which may even require living elsewhere for a while, this freedom is possible. Because there's the confidence that the couple will find each other again. So you'd say. In a... Did you say a great relationship?

I: A high-quality relationship.

P: Of great quality. There would be a lot of laughter, a lot of fun. There would be a lot of spontaneity. There would be risk-taking in projects, either personal or couple-related. There would be change, and that goes a bit for risk-taking. Routine has its positive aspects too, which is good. But there would also be change, which would bring novelty and excitement. But I think the most important thing in a high-quality relationship would be the possibility for each person to accomplish their projects, to fulfill their personal desires. Because I don't think a couple can be aligned with their personal projects all the time. I don't even think it's possible. Everyone is unique, and everyone has personal dreams. For me, a high-quality relationship is one where there's plenty of space to explore individual projects.

I: And how do you know when you're in a relationship where you have that space?

P: Let me give you a personal example. I knew I was in this kind of relationship when, [1-5] years ago, I wanted to go and do some voluntary work in sailing. And [Name] encouraged me, she did some research for me. I was able to go away, for almost [6-10] months in total, on two different volunteer projects. For me, it was a concrete example that this is something that's possible in my relationship. Then, if I wanted to make sure it continued to be the case, how would I know? I'd tell myself what I want today or this year. Do I have the space to talk to [Name] about it? Would she understand me? Would she support me? Encourage me? That's how I'd know.

I: Was there a time when you perhaps had less space?

P: I think there are plenty of times when I've had less space. [Name], she has a personality where she wants affection and to be close, to do the same activities on a daily basis. She knows it and tells me she's a, with all her friendships and family relationships. I often feel a bit attached. If I'm spontaneous about going to do something after work that's different, I'd have to tell her or she'd have to know beforehand. Otherwise, I get the impression that whenever I've had the urge to go off with a friend somewhere, to do something for myself, she's always let me. But I think being back in [Country] means I want to allow myself to do that more than before, to do things without each other. For example, my family lives in [City], while his family lives in the [City]. Sometimes I feel like going back to my family on my own, to reconnect. Ever since we got back, I've been telling her that this weekend I'm going to visit my family. If she wants to come, she can. But I like going on my own too. For example, I went to see a friend in [City] a week ago. I told him I wanted to go on my own. Yes, we're getting out of it.

I: Now, on the contrary, what would a low-quality relationship be for you?

P: A low-quality relationship would be one where I have doubts about my partner's feelings. Doubts about whether she still likes our relationship? Or on the contrary, could she decide at any moment that it's over? The doubts would be generated by poor communication, because I wouldn't know what was going on. It could come up at any moment. It would be a relationship where there's really no understanding. The other person is closed, they can't understand my point of view. A relationship where the other person doesn't pay attention to how they can make me feel. For example, if I can be jealous too often and the other person plays with that, it wouldn't suit me. A low-quality relationship would be one where it's taken for granted, that it'll last a lifetime, and there's no more effort made on either side to keep the excitement, the love going.

I: How can you tell if you're in a relationship where there's a lack of understanding?

P: In my opinion, you can tell when you're keeping things to yourself, when you feel you can't talk about what's bothering you, when you're more likely to talk about your problems with your friends or loved ones, because you're not able to solve them or talk about them with your partner. [Silence] I think that's a lot, for me at least, in terms of feeling. You don't feel good. For example, in my previous relationship, I didn't feel like being there, I felt like being somewhere else, I felt like running away from the arguments. I wanted to end the relationship. I think those would be signals. Wanting to end the relationship, no longer wanting to see the person, wanting to feel better.

I: I'd like you to tell us about the things, if we have any, that you could talk to us about, things that are important in a relationship.

P: I think intimacy is important too. And these are questions I'm asking myself at the moment, because it's sometimes difficult to have sex with [Name], well, [Name] and me. I'm not saying that [Name] is the problem, but... So it's something she's working on a lot, on her side, in therapy. She comes up with a lot of solutions. So that's great. She puts things in place so that we can both be satisfied. I think intimacy is important, I'm sure it is. But it can take different forms. That it can be as simple as cuddling, or moments, for example, in the shower, but where there's not necessarily sexual intercourse. I like physical contact. So for me, it's important that there's some. There is in our relationship, because [Name], as I said, describes herself as a [redacted]. So we're going to block each other all the time, well all the time, no, but once a day, we have at least one close friend

at some time of the day, even several. The questions I ask myself are: what am I looking for in terms of intimacy? Is what we have today enough for me? And as she proposes new things, maybe things will evolve for the better. I think I felt more comfortable with intimacy than she did at the beginning of our relationship, when I had no problem saying "I want to have sex", "let's have sex this weekend". And as it was a problem for her, even then, she regularly rejected my proposals. And so, this couple activity became a bit more of a burden. I had the impression that I was going to feel my urge, and then have to hold it back, repress it, because [Name] wouldn't have the same urge. And so now, on the contrary, I'm going to be more reserved, because sometimes I'm afraid that instead of it being a pleasant moment, and a complicity, and fun, it'll become a kind of exercise, where afterwards we'll have to talk about it. And that's fine, we have to talk about it. But it seems more complicated than it should. But at the same time, that's the way it is. I'm not going to ask [Name] to solve her problems on her own. So I have my share in that. But this closeness remains important in your relationship? The closeness is still there, yes. And intimacy, for the time being, remains important to me. And I think we've got some way to go. But it's not impossible.

I: I'd like you to tell us about your experiences and what love means to you. It could be love in a relationship, love in friendship. I like this question, because I feel love in friendship. But that rarely happens. It has to be a friendship match that makes it happen. I like love in general. And I don't want it to be restricted to one person. When I was a student, there were [1-5] of us living with my colloquialisms, three guys. I don't remember how we described ourselves, but I think we were a bit of a mess. What was it again? A word that mixed friendship and love. I think we invented two colloquialisms to describe our relationship. And I loved it. And for me, that means sitting close together on the sofa, watching the same film together, physical contact again. It gives me chills to describe it. Or being comfortable driving in a car without talking, being comfortable talking about how you feel, being happy to see each other again, cuddling, reuniting. And that's easy enough for me to do with a guy when it's the game, say, with my colloquia, for example. But it can be trickier, I find, with girls, girl family, because I have the impression of not being sure what I'm looking for at the time, of being a bit seductive at the same time. I still wonder, does it harm a friendship? Well, maybe not in all friendships. Maybe there are friendships that function with this kind of excitement or rapport that we also like each other physically, maybe that's it. But I don't know, it's a subject that I love, it's a subject that love, in friendship or in a relationship, I think it's great, I think it's beautiful, because we feel things, we experience things, we can be afraid of "does the other person feel the same way?" It can completely take over your head and it's all you can think about, all you can think about is the other person. It's as if everything else, all the other little problems in life or the little details, the little frustrations disappear. It becomes the most important thing. Me, anyway, sometimes I feel, I can shake, I don't know how to talk anymore. I love that, I love that feeling.

I: Would you say it's the most important thing in a relationship?

P: That's a good question, because I don't know how possible it is in a very long relationship for it to continue to exist. I think I expect it's normal that it's not there every day, that you see the same person so much every day for so long that you get used to their presence, you're not surprised by much anymore. There are fewer secrets, there are fewer mysteries, there are lots of things that aren't like when you first meet someone. But I think it's important for that to happen from time to time. I don't know if it's once every [6-10] months when something really happens, when you feel something strong for the person you're in a relationship with. Was the question about the couple?

I: It can be in relation to the couple or even in friendship itself.

P: In friendship, I find that it's a bit easier to continue to feel love or this feeling because there are longer pauses when we don't see each other. So there are reunions, and you continue to discover the person. And as a couple, I don't know, I'd like to feel that more often. I think it was last week when I heard a podcast of someone who said she'd left her partner after [6-10] years because she didn't feel that way anymore. And that she'd found someone again and it was love at first sight. I wonder, I ask myself, would I ever need to do that? Or can I have my friendships to feel that way? Or other encounters where there's this sort of love at first sight but it'll stop at love at first sight. Yeah, it's simple.

I: And precisely, around love, we know that there are different ways of loving or expressing love. I'd like you to tell me how you know [Partner's Name] loves you.

P: I know because she tells me all the time. She tells me that she loves me and I also tell her that I can see that she counts on me, that I'm important to her. She has detentions from time to time, and this week she brought me a piece of cake because she went to have tea with a friend. It's a small gesture. She likes us to be in physical contact. She compliments me. And I can also see that she wants me to blossom. She supports me in my projects, she encourages me. She wants to find solutions when things are more difficult or don't work so well. That tells me she cares about us. It's all the signs that tell me she loves me. It's expressed in different ways, through words and gestures.

I: I'd like you to tell me about one of the last positive interactions you had with [Partner's Name].

P: Last night, we were saying to each other - I think she brought it up - that she'd like to make love again. I told her over the weekend that I'd rather do it during the day than in the evenings during the week, when I feel that evenings during the week are more of a task to be done, whereas during the day you have more energy, you can find yourself more, you take more time. Last night, she told me that she'd be getting her period soon, so if we wanted to make love, it'd have to be soon, because if not, as she says, it's going to be a long time coming. She suggested that it could be lunchtime, for example, when I leave the coworker where I am, and we eat together and make love. It's something we've never done at that time before. It was a positive interaction, because it proposed something new, something intimate, and that's something exciting.

I: And on the contrary, I'd like you to tell me about one of the informative mistakes you made.

P: Yeah. It was this weekend, and I was taking a shower, and I saw the music that didn't suit her, and I didn't know it wouldn't suit her, it wasn't voluntary, and it was too loud for her. She came into the bathroom and said, "You're such a pain with your music, it's taking over your head", and I don't remember what she said, so she turned it down. It's a bit of a gesture, a way of saying it. After turning down the music, she went to do a meditation in a room in the apartment, which is her study, but she left the door open. After my shower, I went to put away the last things on the table before we went to bed. That disturbed her, because it was making a lot of noise when I opened a cupboard and put the chocolate away. She said, "Honestly, you're overdoing it, you're a pain, you have no respect for what I do, you can see I'm meditating, you're making noise all over the place". I replied that I was just putting the last things away before we went to bed. I was careful not to make too much noise, because I hadn't started the dishwasher. I said, "You start the dishwasher, I'm

going to bed”. It was a negative interaction, because she wasn't happy about something I was doing. And I didn't agree with this reproach, because as far as I was concerned, if she wanted silence, she should have already closed her office door. And then, as far as I was concerned, we were sharing the apartment, so it was normal for me to make everyday noises, especially when it came to tidying up before bedtime. I wasn't sure how our disagreement was going to be resolved. I was really angry with her, and she was angry with me. When she came back into the room, we talked and she explained that the music had frustrated her. She explained that it hadn't been deliberate, that it was random. Anyway, I told her exactly what I just told you, that if she wanted silence, she had to close the door, that the noises of tidying up were normal noises for me, and that nobody would expect the other person to stop moving around the apartment because you wanted to meditate. And so it was resolved quite quickly, but I said to him, I have the impression that you left the door open almost on purpose, because, obviously, I was going to come back into the flat after my shower and there would be noise, and that would create this, and that's it, we explained. It was quickly defused, and I actually appreciate it... At the time, I thought, she's a pain in the ass. And I said to her, afterwards, you were a pain, and she said yes, I was a pain. So at the time, I said to myself, this is unpleasant, I don't want this, why is she so annoying? In other words, a bit of a closed attitude, turned against her. And afterwards, looking back, it's also positive, in fact, because we get angry with each other, but we make up, and so something happened, there was life, there were emotions. So I wouldn't want everything to be smooth and we'd never be angry with each other.

I: And so, in this interaction, the negative was the disagreement over the reproaches?

P: Ah, that cut it a bit. Ah, that's good.

I: So, I don't know if you heard, I was telling you, the negative in this interaction was the disagreement over the reproaches?

P: Yeah, the negative was... In fact, it's also a subject we've had before, for example, sometimes she has to consult, she's a psychologist, and so she has to consult online, and so she asks me not to make any noise in the apartment, except that I can be clumsy, and then it happens, what, for me, anyway, that a door makes a little more noise, that a floorboard makes noise, and so we disagree on... She says she wouldn't make any noise, she'd just lie down on the bed, and for as long as I need, she'd accept it, and she'd be completely silent. And I tell her that I appreciate that she'd be able to do that, but that I don't expect it of her, already, if I ask her for silence, she can keep moving, and I feel too much like a prisoner, you know. If she tells me to stay in the room, on the bed for an hour, I can accept it once, because there's something really special, there has to be no noise, but if it's once a week, for me, that wouldn't be possible, she'd have to find another way, or accept that I move around the apartment. And so, the negative interaction was to notice once again that she has expectations that seem too high to me, and we don't agree on that, in fact, we don't understand each other. I tell her that I wouldn't expect that of her, that I don't think many people would expect that of their partner. And this time, she says “I feel like these days, you're getting defensive and saying that no one would ever ask that of you”. And yes, I feel like recently I've been a bit more assertive when something doesn't suit me. So I think what makes it hard for me is that it's asking a lot of me to be assertive. And I'm afraid of being disappointed in myself, of not having succeeded in

expressing what didn't suit me. So, for me, there's something at stake here, in fact, which increases the intensity of the mini-problem we're saving.

I: I don't know if it's related, but you talked about challenges, and I'd like you to tell me about challenges, if you feel there are any in your relationship.

P: There's one, there's lots, I think. One is intimacy. I've already talked about that, but you'll let me know if you want me to talk more about it. There's the challenge of knowing whether you want children or not. In fact, whether you want a child or not. I'm on the fence, actually. Sometimes, I tell myself that I'm fine without children, that I'm freer, less constrained, less free, also in the sense that I'm less attached to [Name] by something, by a person. And sometimes, I think I'd wake up a lot to raise a child, to see how the child grows up and everything. And receive, we were talking about love, but family can also be the source of a lot of love. I don't feel that's been the case in my family, with my parents, even though I have this... I feel this need. I like it when [Name] shows me love, or even when her parents do it for me. So I feel like I'd like to give some too. And if I had a child, I'd like that. So it's a challenge, because [Name] never imagined herself as a mother. And I can see that she's not at all sure what she would or wouldn't want. And I'm not sure either, because I want us to want it. Both of us. So, it's a challenge, but... In fact, I'm having a bit of trouble finding out what I really want in this project of having a child. Is it, for example, something that would make me think about changing my relationship, because it's too important for me, and [Name], it's never going to be that she wants a child, and that, well, there are other ways of living your life than the one that's kind of the model, where you have to have a child, children. But... I don't know if it's such a challenge for couples, but I have the impression that, in either case, we could live happily ever after. It's not as if I absolutely have to convince [Name] that we should have a child. And the same goes for intimacy. Maybe yes, it wouldn't be enough, maybe I wouldn't be okay with that lack of intimacy. Or maybe I'd be able to feel things differently. Are there any other challenges at the moment? Couples challenge, that is... I think there's always the challenge of pleasing each other and that... So, for me to please and for her to please me. In my opinion, we take care of that a little. But... It's as if there were less... It wasn't as necessary as it was in the beginning, because it was a bit more taken for granted. And I think it's a challenge maybe to keep the attraction for each other. Again, maybe not every day. I don't even think it's possible, I don't know, maybe. But once in a while, you know, we like each other once in a while.

I: Are there any challenges you've overcome in the past?

P: Yeah, it was a challenge not to see each other for almost [6-10] months in total, [1-5] years ago. And it worked out great. Sometimes we weren't on the same wavelength when we called each other. There was already a six-hour time difference. I was in a totally new environment, meeting people, being outdoors, doing lots of things, living my best life. And she was in the routine of work, so we weren't always on the same wavelength. But we stayed close by message, by call. We wrote each other a card a week, a letter a week. And we got on really well as a result. So it was a challenge, yeah, to be away from each other for a long time. There were the challenges of moving in together the first time, about, for example, expectations in terms of cleaning, in terms of tidying up. It worked out well because I adapted to his tidying and cleaning requirements. But it's true that this is also a challenge that I didn't mention before, but a current one. I tell her from time to time, and more recently, that I like it when there's life in the house, so not everything is put away the second

it's used or taken out. And when we went to Montreal a few weeks ago, we stayed with some friends, who used to be our old apartment. So we found ourselves in our old apartment, but at their place. And it was so nice, we were like roommates for a week. And they left things behind. We finished the evening meal and the bottle of wine, or I don't know what came out, the hood of the piano, whatever, things, traces in fact of what happened the day before, which are still visible the next day. So I let him see them a little, although I thought it was nice when things weren't quite tidy. There are positives, and that doesn't mean we're going to lose control, or that things are going to get messy. And so, among the successful challenges, moving in together. We went on a two-month trip together to Argentina. We were together 24/7 and it went really well. Oh yes, there's also a challenge that's still a bit topical, but [Name]'s relationship with her family is sometimes complicated. And so when I'm with her in her family, or her family comes to stay with us, I can sometimes feel uncomfortable, lose my place, they argue. And it's been a challenge in the past to feel a bit secondary in that moment. She doesn't see me anymore. But when I first talked to her about it, it was really difficult for me. In fact, we were still at home, with her family, when I spoke to her about it. And so she wasn't able, I think, at that time to hear me, to understand me. And so she said to me, "Well, you're a bit fragile, it's okay, you'll get over it, I've got other problems at the moment than looking after you". And we were able to discuss it again afterwards. And now she understands me better and she even asks me to tell her, it's her request, she tells me "tell me if I'm a pain in the ass with my parents, if I'm a pain in the ass with you." So there you have it, she agrees to let me share my feelings about the situation. I think that covers all the challenges. So we know that not everything in a relationship is brand new. You touched on conflict a little at the beginning, very quickly.

I: I'd like you to tell me about any conflicts or arguments you may have in your relationship?

P: There aren't many, and they don't usually last long. And recently, she and I were talking about the fact that there aren't many conflicts because I don't really get involved. As I told you, I don't like being angry with anyone. So it's not going to do me any good to start talking aggressively. So I prefer to resolve the situation. But on the other hand, if it's something that's too important to me and I'm too much at odds with either my values or what I'm trying to improve, such as asserting myself, I'll keep my point of view and try to defend it or explain it. But there was a conflict not so long ago that was quite strong. I'd just come back from a weekend I'd spent in [City] with my friend. [Name] had just returned from a weekend she'd spent with her friend in her region. We arrived at the apartment at about the same time, like 8.30 pm on Sunday. And we'd agreed that we'd change rooms. It's a two-bedroom, so we're lucky. Before the weekend, we said we'd rather take the other room, which is a bit further back in the apartment, cosier. And I couldn't wait to make the switch. Before the weekend, I asked him "Would you like to help me? Shall we move the bed?" No, we'll do it on Sunday. And I thought that on Sunday at 9pm, she wouldn't feel like taking apart an Ikea bed and moving the mattress. Whereas me, I like doing that, I'm not tired of the change. I'm in a bit of a rush. So I arrived before she did and started dismantling the bed. I'd arranged to make myself a sandwich for the train, so I'd already eaten. When she came back into the apartment, she saw that I was dismantling the bed at 9pm and hadn't made any food. She was frustrated that I hadn't gone ahead and made dinner for her. And actually, it really frustrated me too, because I'd felt free to do whatever I wanted on the weekend with my buddy. And now, as soon as we got together, I'd have to make dinner so that when she arrived, it would be ready. So I said to her, it's really nice that we're

getting together like this, but we're going to have to change something. And it took a while, it took longer than usual, because it went downhill maybe an hour, half an hour. Which isn't very long, I don't think. And she said she was sorry for being in a bad mood when she arrived. But that time, I didn't really see the positive side of the conflict. Instead, I said to myself, this is a pain in the ass. She hadn't asked me to prepare food for her when she arrived. I thought she might even have eaten on her way here too. And all of a sudden, I had the impression that since we were getting back together, all the activities had to be done together again. She said, "I'd have cooked for you if I'd got to you first. And I said thank you, but I don't have that expectation. I expect to have to take care of myself, not that you made me dinner. And at that moment, I said to myself, I've got to feel freer. Because I don't like it, I don't feel good having to pay attention to every activity I choose to do, because it's the right one. And generally speaking, how do you resolve these conflicts? Generally speaking, I take a step towards her, because I don't like the situation of being angry. So, if he's upstairs, can we have a hug? Can we make up? And sometimes, she's not ready. So, no. She's still angry. And generally speaking, she comes and finds me, then smiles and says "sorry". And for me, those moments are a relief, because I tell myself "ok, she's not going to sulk all evening, she's not going to make me feel bad". We're still able to understand each other and things are going to get pleasant again. So that's how it often gets resolved. I show her that I want us to make peace, to get back together. And when she's ready, she shows me that she's ready too, and then we talk about it. But it's relaxed, because we also talk about it when we're angry, about expressing ourselves. I told her "but I didn't have to cook for you, I want to do this, move your bed, we said we'd do it". And I also told her, at that moment, when I was angry, "it's really unpleasant, we have to find a solution, it's not working". And she'd reply that it didn't suit her at all. But in general, I think we both know that we're not going to resolve the conflict at that point. So we let it go for a while, and it never takes long. The good thing is that we don't have to be in our corners for a whole day before we can talk about it. And I have a friend, with his girlfriend, they used to live together, they're not together anymore. And he said to me "we haven't spoken for a day now". And I was shocked, because it must be really nice to see someone at home without talking to each other. So every time I say to myself "I'm glad [Name] and I are defusing the situation". That's a very important point for me. And it all comes down to communication? Yeah, it's always about communication. We always manage to say why we were angry at the time. What happened? And generally you say... I say "yes, I can understand". Or she can.

I: I'd like to know what other ways you maintain your relationship?

P: I regularly ask myself what activities we've done together recently. It could be a weekend away, it could just be going to the movies or out to dinner. Something different from the daily routine. So when it's been a while, I suggest we do something. So that's one way I maintain our relationship. The thoughtful gift-giving is quite rare, and is usually for birthdays and Christmas. But not all the time. Sometimes, just the two of us, we haven't really taken the time to think about a gift that would please. But when we do, and I think we often do, it works. I can see she's really thought it through. What are my interests? What would give me pleasure? And I too really rack my brains to find something she'll like. And it often works. We're happy with this attention, which shows that we know the other person, that we know what pleases them, that we're paying attention right now. We know what the other person's passions are.

I: So, at some point, we go through the attentions together?

P: Yes.

I: On the other hand, I'd like to know what could make you leave [Name]?

P: If moments of conflict like moving the bed or playing music became really frequent, every day for example, or if she prevented me from going to see friends or doing something at the weekend or whatever in the evening. That would make me, I think, leave [Name] because on a day-to-day basis, it wouldn't suit me. I'd feel trapped, I'd feel trapped in fact in both cases. I don't have the freedom to do what I want. What would make me leave [Name] is if she didn't see me anymore. It can happen, I notice that she's, I have these moments too, but she's absorbed by her work in the evening or by second-hand purchases she wants to make or who knows what else. And so if it was all the time, if we didn't get together, if we didn't have moments where we connected with each other, at least once a day, I don't think it would suit me anymore. It would be a sign that we'd lost something, and that we might have to consider a change. And then, if intimacy is a problem all the time and she decides she doesn't want to try and solve it or improve it any more, I don't know, one day it might weigh too much on me and I'd like to find it again with someone else maybe, I don't know. For the moment, I say no to myself. I tell myself it doesn't weigh on me enough to be a reason to leave [Name]. And the same goes for the kids. Right now, I'm not convinced enough that I absolutely want to live with a child. So that wouldn't be a good enough reason right now. Ah, but if [Name], for example, were to cheat on me, I think I'd understand her, because I too can sometimes want to feel that way again. So far, I've never cheated on her. But I find it hard to believe that you can love the same person all your life and be attracted to the same person exclusively. So if she were to cheat on me, I think it would be a good opportunity to discuss how our relationship could work if we were more open and free. Right now, I don't dare talk to her about it. I'm afraid she'll say to herself "that's it, she's not attracted to me anymore", that she'll get scared. But what could make me leave [Name] would be if she fell in love with someone else and thought of nothing but that person and wanted to see him or her all the time, and didn't see me anymore. And then I'd say to myself that we both have to do something.

I: Would you say that this relationship is good for you?

P: Yes, really. I think it's a relationship that has made me regain confidence in expressing my desires, expressing my dissatisfactions. It's also a relationship that's opened me up a lot to, for example, feminism, trans-identity, the problems that other people can encounter in their lives and which mean that, some days, communication just doesn't work with someone. But that can be explained by a lot of things I don't see. Like shrinks, they sometimes tell me about customers who are there. It makes me realize that everyone goes through difficult things. So I'm more accepting of other people's faults and moods. This relationship also made me think about my family, because the Lu[Name]t family dynamic is very different from mine. And it made me open my eyes to the fact that my family isn't perfect at all. So this relationship is really good for me, for all those reasons.

I: Yes, it's taught you things, it's allowed you to evolve.

P: Yes, definitely.

I: Which brings me to my next question, which is whether you feel you're the same person as before, or whether you feel you've changed.

P: Thanks to [Name]?

I: Yes, thanks to this relationship.

P: Yes, I feel like the same person, [name]. But I've evolved a lot, I've... I was in therapy for [1-5] year and a half. So I questioned myself, I opened my eyes to things. I think I'm getting out of that box a bit. A guy's got to be that way. So, I'm evolving in that. I think I'm connecting more with who I really am. I'm the same person and I know myself even more than I did before this relationship.

I: So, there's a knowledge about yourself, you've really had a change?

P: It's not a profound change, but still something I've changed. I think it's partly thanks to this relationship, but in terms of how I used to party. I used to drink a lot in the evening and I don't do that anymore. Maybe it's other reasons, but in any case, I've changed in that respect. It's a big change for me.

I: And what about [Partner's Name], do you feel she's your generator?

P: I'd say no. I feel like she's always been this person who supports me, who listens to me, that she's always been able to do that. That she still looks like the person I met [6-10] years ago. If I think she's changed, maybe it's how she perceives men, or certain men. Because when I met her, she told me "I don't want a relationship, guys are all assholes, so we won't have one, that's not what I'm looking for". And then we talked about it again, that at the time that's how she felt about men. And so I may have changed her perception a little that not all men are assholes. But on the whole, I'd say she stayed true to herself.

I: I'd like to know if you feel secure in this relationship?

P: Yeah, I think there's one thing I have no doubt about, and that's that she's Roman and she'd like it to last a lifetime. After that, it's contradictory to what I'm saying, I wonder how it's possible to love someone for life. I'd rather we didn't take that for granted, etc. So maybe I'm reassuring myself. So maybe I'm reassuring myself that it's unconditional, the love she sees for me, and that it'll never stop. But in any case, whether it's true or just what I tell myself, the result is that I feel safe.

I: Do you also feel that you can open up and that she'll support you?

P: Yeah, then there are subjects like opening up another couple where I don't feel comfortable talking to her about it. I feel safe to a certain extent.

I: Now, I'd like to talk a bit about sexuality. We know that it's a dimension that's more or less important in couples. You told me that it was quite important for you. Would you like to expand on this a little?

P: I think it's intimacy that's important, and that can involve sexuality. But I see sexuality as a game, as something fun. People have to respect each other. A game that must be consensual and that both people feel the same way. That it's a game and that we're having a good time. And that it's pleasant and fun. That's important to me because it makes me happy when it happens like that. It's something that contributes to happiness for me. But it's not compulsory. A life without sex can be very happy. That's a question I'm asking myself today. Right now, I mean, what am I looking for in intimacy? What makes me happy? What could [Name] and I possibly have in common? And there

you have it, being able to afford that happiness. But there are lots of happinesses in life and I don't enjoy them all. I'm not sure how to explain that. Maybe there are other ways of being happy.

I: Are you satisfied with your sex life?

P: No, I'd say not. But I have my share in it. It can become yes if I invest as much as [Name] in finding solutions. And accept that it's not a natural subject for everyone. And that there may be moments of embarrassment, doubt, frustration or even disappointment.

I: I see, thank you. Finally, you're going to show us some scales.

P: OKAY.

I: I don't know if I can manage it.

P: Just while you're loading that up, I'll pop to the loo.

I: Yes, don't worry.

P: OK.

I: Let me show you a little bit about my ladders.

P: OK.

P: I'd say 5.

I: 5 ?

P: Yeah.

I: Why 5?

P: Er... 5 because it's halfway between... It's still a relationship that suits me. And there are things we can do better.

I: OK. All right, then. So, you can tell me about your labs and your patient. And in the second moment, you can tell me about your labs. And so, that's the envelope.